Describing the Zombie

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[2025-11-06 Thu]

0. Orientation — From Representation to Ontology

Critical attention to the zombie has long revolved around its representational elasticity. Within cultural studies the figure is treated as a mirror for historical anxieties: colonial servitude, viral globalization, consumerism, environmental collapse. Yet these readings, while valuable, leave an unasked question at the center of their interpretive field: **what is the zombie such that it can bear so many metaphoric burdens without ceasing to be itself?** The present study answers not through another catalogue of meanings but by describing the *zombie as an ontological form*—a particular configuration of life, death, and relation that recurs whenever vitality is detached from reflexivity.

To describe a thing ontologically is to locate the conditions that make its recurrence possible across historical and medial change. The Haitian **zonbi** of the nineteenth-century penal code, the cinematic revenant of Romero's 1968 film, and the viral "infected" of twenty-first-century fiction all differ empirically; nevertheless, they share an internal grammar: animation without interiority, motion without self-relation, persistence without world. This grammar is what demands explanation. Following the methodological gesture of Foucault's **archaeology of discourse**, the task is not to recover origins but to articulate the **field of intelligibility** that allows "undeath" to appear as a meaningful category.

The approach is therefore trans-disciplinary but conceptually unified. Biopolitical and necropolitical theory (Foucault, Agamben, Mbembe) provide the structural account of how life becomes a governable object; philosophies of immunity and community (Esposito, Haraway) explain the boundary conditions that sustain or fail that governance; and philosophies of life (Canguilhem, Simondon) expose how vitality persists when normative and individuating structures collapse. Together they delineate the zombie as a

mode of being produced within, and revealing of, the modern regime that governs life through its capacity for indefinite survival. The zombie, in this sense, is not a monster outside the order of life—it is the point at which that order becomes visible to itself.

1. Genealogical Grounding — The Zonbi and the Modern Imaginary

1.1 Haitian Ontology: Will, Law, Labor

The Haitian **zonbi** emerges within a world still structured by the afterlife of plantation slavery. In Vodou cosmology it denotes a person whose **ti bon anj**, the spiritual component governing intention, has been captured; the body remains animated but its will is suspended. This condition was not metaphorical: Haitian penal law, revised in 1864, explicitly criminalized the creation of a "zombie," treating it as a form of homicide that left the victim in a living death. The law recognizes a **socially real category of undeath*—a being deprived of autonomy yet still belonging to the community as laboring matter. Ontologically, the *zonbi** occupies a liminal space: not corpse, not person, but an instrument that continues to work. It is a life stripped of relation to its own desire, a will externalized into the command of another.

This original formation already contains the essential structure later magnified by modern media. The **zonbi** is **life without self-relation**, animated function divorced from consciousness. In the plantation economy that birthed it, the figure made literal the logic of slavery: production sustained by bodies emptied of personhood. To call someone a **zonbi** was not to fantasize about the supernatural; it was to describe an ontological state produced by political economy.

1.2 Colonial Translation and Displacement

When U.S. occupation and travel writing exported the **zonbi** into Western imagination—most famously through W. B. Seabrook's **The Magic Island** (1929)—the juridical and theological dimensions collapsed into spectacle. The racialized fear of "animated black labor" was recoded as exotic horror for white audiences. In this translation, the ontological content—life deprived of will—was severed from its colonial context and reattached to a metaphysical fantasy of reanimation. The zombie became **a corpse that moves**, not **a**

person whose agency is owned. Yet what persisted through this distortion was the structural kernel: the **continuance of bodily function after the disappearance of interiority**. The displacement thus globalized the figure's ontology while obscuring its political origin.

1.3 Romero's Inversion: From Enslaved to Autonomous Contagion

The decisive modern transformation arrives with George A. Romero's **Night of the Living Dead** (1968). Here the zombie ceases to be a servant of sorcery and becomes an **autonomous process**: death itself becomes productive, spreading by contact. The social fear inverts—what once symbolized submission now symbolizes the failure of control. Yet the invariant remains: animation without selfhood. The zombie still functions without interiority, only now that absence has multiplied into the many. The body politic, not the plantation master, is the one losing command.

Romero's shift marks the moment when the zombie becomes the privileged figure of *biopolitical anxiety*—the nightmare not of rebellion but of administration. The living-dead mass threatens not because it is evil but because it is ungovernable, because it manifests a life that cannot be reintegrated into law or purpose. The zombie therefore does not oppose the social order; it reveals the fragility of its mechanisms for distinguishing vitality from decay.

2. The Zombie and the Government of Life

To understand why the zombie recurs wherever modernity governs life, we must first specify what "governed life" entails. Foucault's account of biopower describes a fundamental reorientation of sovereignty: power no longer takes life or lets live, but **makes live and lets die**. Life becomes an object of administration, subject to surveillance, optimization, and correction. Yet once life is thus instrumentalized, it is also perpetually at risk of losing its capacity for self-determination. In a regime that governs through vitality, the ultimate horror is not death but a *life that endures beyond its subject*—a persistence emptied of meaning. The zombie is the diagram of this horror: a form of living stripped of the capacity to withdraw from life.

Agamben gives this condition its juridical articulation. In **Homo Sacer** he names **bare life** as the residue produced when inclusion in political order is achieved through exclusion from its rights. The concentration camp is the paradigmatic site where the distinction between inside and outside collapses;

the living are retained only as killable bodies. The zombie radicalizes this paradox. It is bare life extended beyond its own death, held in a continuous state of exception. Every quarantine zone in zombie fiction reproduces Agamben's topological logic: zones where killing the infected is lawful precisely because they remain alive. The zombie body is the figure through which the law reveals its dependency on the suspension of life.

Achille Mbembe's concept of **necropolitics** clarifies the next turn of the screw. Biopower, he argues, inevitably shades into the power to decide who may live and who must die. Modernity's dream of protecting life generates death-worlds—spaces where populations are maintained in the state of being-dead. The zombie belongs to this necropolitical landscape as its most literal inhabitant. It is not the victim of sovereign power's violence but its ongoing product: the life that is kept from dying so that killing may continue as management. The camp, the plantation, and the apocalypse all converge in this figure of **permanent survivorship**. Death is no longer an end; it is the regime through which life is administered.

The mechanism that sustains this administration is what Roberto Esposito calls the **immunitary paradigm**. To preserve itself, a system introduces controlled exposure to its own negation; immunity is the inclusion of death as a safeguard of life. Modern societies conceive of the body politic as an organism to be protected by boundary, barrier, or vaccine. The zombie marks the moment this logic turns against itself. Infection overwhelms containment; the body's distinction from its environment collapses. The immunitary circuit loops inward, producing autoimmunity—life destroyed by its own defense. The zombie's bite is the emblem of this collapse: protection and contagion are indistinguishable. In that sense, the zombie is not an external threat to immunitary modernity but its internal truth, the embodiment of life's dependence on its own negation.

Within this same matrix, Georges Canguilhem's philosophy of the normal and the pathological exposes the epistemic fragility of "health." For Canguilhem, the pathological is not an inversion of the normal but a mode of life that can no longer create new norms. To live is to set a standard for one's own functioning; to be sick is to lose that capacity. The zombie exemplifies pathology in this precise sense. It operates, metabolizes, moves, but cannot re-norm itself—it cannot reinterpret its environment or reorient its existence. It therefore occupies a state of **vitality without normativity**, a persistence that endures only by repeating the same motion. Canguilhem's analysis reveals why the zombie's horror lies not in its violence but in its mechanical indifference: it lives on without the power to value.

The ontology of this paralysis can be deepened through Gilbert Simon-

don's theory of individuation. For Simondon, the individual is not a given substance but a process by which pre-individual potential becomes structured through relation. Each living being continuously negotiates tensions between interior and milieu; life is the ongoing resolution of that tension. The zombie appears where this process has stalled. It is a being in which metastability persists without resolution: energy circulates, but no new relation emerges. Its body is self-propelled yet non-individuating—a system deprived of internal difference. The horde, in turn, is not a collective but a field of such un-relations, contiguity without communication. Simondon's ontology thus clarifies the zombie as the **limit form of individuation**, where relation has collapsed into pure propagation.

Seen through these lenses together, the zombie ceases to be a monster and becomes a **metaphysical remainder**: the living residue left when the political, biological, and relational apparatuses that define modern life exceed their own coherence. Foucault gives the general condition (life under administration); Agamben, the juridical form (life in exception); Mbembe, the sovereign practice (life maintained in death); Esposito, the mechanism (life immunized against itself); Canguilhem, the biological symptom (life without norm); Simondon, the ontogenetic consequence (life without individuation). Their convergence describes a single phenomenon: life persisting after its capacity for self-relation has vanished.

The zombie is the articulation of this convergence. It is the point where governance, biology, and ontology coincide in failure. As such, it does not simply illustrate the crisis of modern life—it constitutes that crisis's ontological expression. To encounter the zombie is to see the project of making-live completed to absurdity: life so perfectly secured that it can no longer end.

3. Phenomenology of Undeath: Time, Affect, and Relation

If the preceding section established the zombie as a form of life in which reflexivity has collapsed, then the phenomenological question becomes: **what is it like for such a world to persist?** What kind of time, feeling, and relation are possible once life no longer has access to its own end? The answer is not psychological—zombies do not possess consciousness—but structural. The world that contains them, and the humans who survive beside them, is governed by the same ontological exhaustion. The phenomenology of undeath is the atmosphere of this exhaustion made visible.

3.1 Temporal Suspension — Time Without Event

Zombic time is neither cyclical nor teleological; it is a continuous present deprived of closure. The apocalypse does not occur; it **has always already occurred**, and everything that follows is maintenance. In this temporality the future exists only as repetition—of guarding, scavenging, surviving. The living and the undead share the same temporal regime: ongoingness without horizon. Lauren Berlant's notion of **slow death** names this state precisely—the condition of "living on in the state of attrition." It is a temporality of management, not of narrative. The zombie is not an agent of apocalypse but the sign that apocalypse has become **routine**.

This temporality can be read as the existential corollary of biopolitical governance. When life is optimized rather than liberated, duration replaces destiny. The state promises survival, not salvation; medical and economic infrastructures extend life but no longer orient it. The zombie thus inhabits what we might call *administrative time*—a duration stripped of transformation. Its movement is locomotion without voyage, process without becoming. The dread it inspires arises from the recognition that our own historical time increasingly resembles it: progress converted into persistence.

3.2 Affective Flattening — Life Without Interior Tone

Affect within zombic worlds is defined not by intensity but by its absence. The undead do not rage; they persist. Their affective neutrality mirrors the desaturated affect of those who fight them. Survival horror is not primarily a genre of terror but of **exhaustion**: of bodies and feelings stretched past responsiveness. The emotional field oscillates between numb vigilance and procedural dread—the same tonal register Berlant calls the **impasse**, a condition "where the usual frameworks of desire and expectation have dissolved but nothing has replaced them."

If traditional monsters externalize forbidden passions—lust, greed, ambition—the zombie externalizes **the absence of passion as such**. Its hunger is mechanical, not libidinal. It desires nothing beyond the act of repetition. In this, the zombie embodies the terminal state of the libidinal economy: consumption without appetite, movement without satisfaction. The affect it generates in viewers or readers—disgust, fascination, fatigue—is the recognition of this zero-degree of feeling, a mirror of our own desensitized vitality.

3.3 Social Form — Contiguity Without Community

The social ontology of undeath extends this flattening into relation. The zombie horde is not a collective but an **aggregate*—a density of bodies bound only by proximity. Its unity is numerical, not relational. Each body moves in parallel to others but never toward them. Communication is replaced by contagion; the only mode of contact is conversion. The horde therefore constitutes the absolute negation of community in Esposito's sense of *communitas**: there is being-together, but no sharing.

Within the surviving human enclaves the same logic reappears in inverted form. The imperative to quarantine, to isolate, to secure, reproduces the immunitary closure that generated the undead in the first place. Every fortress or safe zone is another manifestation of life defended against relation. The community of the living differs from the horde only by degree of organization; both are defined by exclusion as their principle of coherence. In this sense, the zombie is not the Other of the community but its *mirror image*—a community whose only bond is the fear of contamination.

3.4 The World of the Undead — Phenomenal Consequences

A world populated by such beings is perceptually impoverished. Space loses orientation because direction no longer matters; everything is merely nearer or farther from infection. Time thickens; action loops. Meaning contracts to immediate function: kill, consume, barricade, survive. The zombie world is thus not post-apocalyptic but *supra-administrative*—a fully managed reality devoid of transcendence. The spectacle of endless patrolling and repetitive violence exposes the exhaustion of modernity's narrative resources. The event has been replaced by protocol.

This phenomenological reduction completes the ontological picture. Zombic time, affect, and sociality are the experiential correlates of the structural conditions described earlier. Temporal suspension mirrors the collapse of normativity (Canguilhem): when life can no longer institute new norms, it ceases to move toward ends. Affective flattening mirrors the failure of individuation (Simondon): when relation to self and other is lost, feeling loses its differential structure. Contiguity without community mirrors the immunitary collapse (Esposito): boundaries persist only as sites of fear, not exchange.

In these correspondences, the zombie ceases to be a figure inside a world and becomes a description of the world itself—*a world that continues after

relation has died.*

4. Ontological Synthesis — The Zombie as Form of Being

The preceding analyses converge on a paradox: the zombie is not the negation of life but its **pure remainder**. Every attempt to define the living—through will, norm, relation, or law—produces, as its necessary underside, a form of existence that continues when those criteria fail. The zombie is that underside made manifest. It exists wherever life endures without relation to its own finitude, wherever the biological process detaches from the reflexive circuit that once gave it meaning. To name the zombie is therefore to name the **limit of the concept of life itself** within modern thought.

4.1 Life and Reflexivity

Modern biopolitics presupposes that "life" is a substance capable of being known, managed, and improved. Yet what Foucault and Canguilhem both uncover is that life, as such, is never merely biological; it is an activity of self-norming, of continual invention of value. To live is to establish a relation to one's own possible non-being—to die symbolically so that existence can be re-valued. The zombie is the instance where this reflexive capacity has been evacuated while the biological process remains. It **lives without the ability to signify living**. What was once the autonomy of the organism has become automatic continuation. In formal terms, if we call **vitality** the process that sustains form and **reflexivity** the process that gives it meaning, then the zombie equals vitality minus reflexivity. It is the minimal possible form of persistence.

4.2 Negation and Its Failure

Philosophically, the capacity for negation—Hegel's labor of the negative, Heidegger's being-toward-death—is what converts existence into experience. Death gives life its contour. The zombie exhibits the suspension of this relation: a being that can neither die nor live fully. In this sense, undeath is not the triumph over death but *the failure of dying*—the impossibility of completing negation. The body moves, decomposes, feeds; but no event concludes it. What Blanchot calls "the infinite conversation of death" has been silenced. This silencing transforms ontology into maintenance: being

becomes upkeep. The zombie's persistence is thus the metaphysical signature of a world that has abolished death in order to prolong management.

4.3 Governance as Ontology

At this limit, politics and metaphysics coincide. The same operations that administer life—quarantine, optimization, immunization—also describe the structure of being that the zombie inhabits. Its world is composed entirely of systems for keeping alive what should be allowed to end. Every fortified community, every perpetual emergency, is a metaphysical proposition: that survival is more fundamental than relation. The zombie is the citizen of this ontology, the one who verifies by its existence that governance has replaced creation as life's ground. What appears as horror is in fact the logical consequence of biopower's axiom: to govern is to prevent death indefinitely.

4.4 The Zombie as Limit of Relation

From the perspective of Simondon's individuation, relation is what differentiates life from mere process. Each living being resolves tension by forming new structures with its milieu. The zombie cannot. It is closed to the world except as contagion; it reproduces itself by destroying relation. In this, it mirrors the immunitary society that produces it: a community organized around the refusal of exposure. The horde and the quarantine are symmetrical forms—one overflowing boundary, the other sealing it. Both are expressions of life that has lost confidence in its relational capacity. The zombie, therefore, is not external to the social order but the image of its **metaphysical self-understanding**: being as the management of isolation.

4.5 Formal Definition

We may now state the ontological equation explicitly:

> **Zombie = life that has lost the capacity for relation.**
> It is vitality deprived of reflexivity, continuation without norm, existence that cannot end because it has ceased to begin.

This definition condenses all prior determinations:

- from biopolitics, the reduction of life to administration;
- from necropolitics, the governance of survival as death;

- from immunity, the collapse of self and other;
- from Canguilhem, the loss of normativity;
- from Simondon, the failure of individuation;
- from phenomenology, the substitution of maintenance for event.

Each of these describes not a metaphor but a dimension of the same ontological condition.

4.6 Ethical and Metaphysical Implication

To think the zombie is thus to confront the horizon of our own form of life. The zombie is not an other to be overcome but the **mirror of modern being**: we too inhabit systems that prize survival over relation, management over meaning. The ethical question it poses is not how to kill the undead but whether life that cannot die still counts as life. Its slow, relentless movement is a meditation on our own: the march of vitality divorced from world. The only true counter to the zombie, then, is not purification or defense but the re-discovery of a relation that can include death without annihilation—a community capable of ending as well as beginning.

5. Coda — The Zombie as Mirror of the Living

The zombie does not threaten the order of the living; it **reveals** that order. What we fear in its empty eyes is not monstrosity but recognition. The structures that produce it—administration, quarantine, immunity, optimization—are the same structures that organize our daily existence. Its presence is diagnostic, not apocalyptic. It shows that the end of the world has already been accomplished in the slow substitution of relation by management, of meaning by duration.

To describe the zombie, then, is to describe the point at which life's reflexive loop collapses under its own success. The figure condenses the history of biopolitical modernity into an ontology: a life that continues because nothing remains capable of ending it. Against that horizon, the only remaining task is philosophical rather than medical—to imagine another concept of life, one in which finitude is not failure but the ground of relation itself.

Summary Equation: Zombie = Vitality – Reflexivity = Persistence without Relation

The zombie is the being of life prolonged beyond relation, the residue of an ontology that cannot die because it has forgotten how to end.